



option, especially on challenging pitches. Just as often, that same sweep becomes her undoing, with teams planning for it.

"She took those failures back to her brother and worked it out in training. She never abandoned her natural ability to sweep, but added shotmaking all around the ground instead. She worked on her fitness to run the hard singles and twos," Rita points out.

True to her roots

Staying true to what comes naturally while also reinventing herself is a mantra that extends to her life off the field.

Rita describes Deepti as someone who sits in the middle of the introvert-extrovert spectrum. She is happy in her own world and communicates in a way tailored to what the situation demands. Rita calls her an atypical figure in Agra's cultural fabric, where families often ensured girls were supervised everywhere for safety.

"She was not the type to go eat

burgers, pizzas, or lose control over her fitness. It took a lot of convincing to get her to start eating eggs for extra protein; otherwise, she was absolutely fine to manage on homemade daal, chawal, paneer, vegetables, and such. Once her family saw her single-mindedly focused on success here, it eased their nerves, too. It's a lesson for this generation to learn. They need to be supported, but must guard against losing their way and getting distracted.

"I still remember the young teenager who called me from Shopper's Stop asking which pants she should pick with a certain shirt. I remember her asking me if getting an Android phone was the right move for her in 2015, when she saw everyone else already having one. She had small wishes like this from time to time, but never lost track."

Ever curious, she would constantly ask questions about her game, what coaches told her, and why certain ploys did not work the way she

intended. Her father, Bhagwan, who worked for the Railways, and her mother, Sushila, who retired as a government school principal, prioritised education, and Deepti balanced cricket with her studies. Rita encouraged her to work on her English as well.

"Why don't you give Rapidex a shot? How will you do your interviews as an Indian cricketer,' I would ask her. She would take it as a joke and say, '*Meri matrubhasha Hindi hai. Main wahi bolungi* (Hindi is my mother tongue and I will speak Hindi)'. She has picked it up perfectly now, but has not lost her earthiness one bit even today."

To see more girls in sports

When Deepti sat garlanded in the open jeep during her roadshow home, not a tear was visible. The years of crying were behind her, as were the years of overthinking. She had finally brought home the *Raksha Bandhan* gift she had promised her brother eight years earlier. Yet what thrilled her more was bringing home the gift of possibility for countless girls in her hometown, girls who once saw no viable future in sport.

Agra was always famous for the Taj Mahal. Now, it had another wonder, one who exceeded expectations while staying cheekily quiet and endearing.

"Our next goal is to win an Olympic medal and the T20 World Cup," she proudly declared then.

Ask her about legacy, and a probably rehearsed but sincere answer follows. "As many wins for India as I can manage. But I also want to see a boom in participation. I want girls to not just take up sport, but stick with it. Whenever anyone goes to an academy, we should now see them packed with girls."

Rita, meanwhile, is waiting for her frenemy to soak in the adulation, the appearances as Deputy Superintendent of Police, and the invitations from governments and institutions, before calling her home for their usual combination of good food and long conversations.